

Henning Andersen in Section 4 of his 2014 article on Slavic vowel-contractions makes some sweeping claims about the supposed ancientness of certain Old Russian (and Old Czech) imperfect forms which have traditionally been viewed as later analogical formations. At issue are the imperfects of class 4 verbs with infinitives in LCS *-iti, which in Old Church Slavonic build their imperfects exclusively off a jotated form of the stem (e.g. *ношаахъ* < *nos-j-ě-axъ from *nositi*). Old Russian documents, on the other hand, show imperfect forms which appear to derive from the bare, non-jotated stem, e.g. *носѣаху* < *nos-ěaxъ, in addition to jotated forms like *ношааше*. In characteristically deceptive fashion, Andersen constructs his discussion as if the primacy of these OR non-jotated forms were an uncontroversial and well-established fact (p.71 “in OCz. and OR [the LCS infix *-ě-] replaces the Class IV.A marker -i- ”), and even calls the OCS jotated forms “innovated” (p.78-79), without even the slightest attempt to buttress this assertion by any engagement with the actual philological facts. The alternative view is of course that the non-jotated OR forms arose by simple levelling on the basis of the non-jotated stem, as has demonstrably occurred in the attested history of Bulgarian, where the modern imperfects *носех*, *носеше* have been reformed out of the non-jotated stem /nos-/ + the contracted /ěx/ reflex of *ě-axъ, replacing expected ***ношах*, ***ношааше* continuants of the OCS *ношаахъ*, *ношааше*. Russian scholarship takes this levelling explanation for the OR non-jotated imperfects as a given, to the extent that Krys’ko & Petrukhin’s (2020) article on the history of the Russian past tense dedicates just half a sentence to such forms: “у глаголов с основой инф. на -и нередко наблюдается выравнивание основы с устранением чередования, возникшего по йотовой палатализации: *приходяху* вм. *прихожаху*”. Similarly Ivanov (1982: 71) does not adduce any non-jotated class 4 imperfects in his discussion of 11th century East Slavic documents, and mentions them only in his discussion of 12th-14th century, where his choice of words (p.84, “Эти морфонологические чередования в целом **сохраняются** в имперфектных формах и в памятниках X II—XIV вв... однако наряду с ними, причем в достаточно большом количестве случаев, в этих памятниках обнаруживаются и факты отсутствия таких чередований”) suggests that he too considers them a later Old Russian innovation.

The imperfect’s absence from both business documents (charters, treaties etc.) and personal correspondence (Birchbark letters) has long been cited as a reason to doubt its survival in the live spoken language of the Old Russian period, but the existence of these non-jotated class 4 types not found in OCS, as well as the particular OR <ѣх> spelling of contracted *ěax-, which uses the OCS letter for *ę and thus has to be an indigenous development, mean that it cannot have been a wholly literary form borrowed from South Slavic protographs, at least not at the beginning of East Slavic literacy. If Andersen’s claim that non-jotated class 4 forms are the indigenous OR ones is correct, then we would expect...

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Крысько, В.Б. Историческая грамматика русского языка: энциклопедический словарь. Москва. 2020.